

Customer Research Report

Project: Shoebox-to-Books Bookkeeper (AI Receivables Assistant)

Target Users: Pakistani Small FMCG Micro-Distributors

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1. Executive Summary

This document summarizes the customer discovery research conducted during the product selection and MVP definition phase of our AI cohort project.

Rather than validating our proposed solution, we focused on understanding the daily operational challenges faced by Pakistani small FMCG distributors.

Through interviews with business owners, discussions in business communities, and conversations with accounting and ERP professionals, we found that the biggest operational pain is **managing customer receivables** rather than maintaining complete accounting records.

Distributors frequently struggle to answer simple but business-critical questions such as:

- ❖ Which retailers still owe me money?
- ❖ Which invoices are overdue?
- ❖ Which customers made partial payments?
- ❖ Who should I follow up with today?

Information is often scattered across paper invoices, WhatsApp screenshots, bill books, Excel sheets, and basic accounting software. This fragmented workflow makes receivable tracking slow, error-prone, and heavily dependent on manual effort.

These findings led us to narrow our MVP to an **AI-assisted receivables management solution** rather than a general bookkeeping or ERP product.

2. Research Objective

Our research aimed to validate the following questions:

- How do Pakistani FMCG distributors currently manage credit sales?
- How are customer receivables tracked?
- Which manual tasks consume the most time?
- How are invoices currently stored and processed?
- Where can AI provide meaningful assistance?
- Which assumptions must be validated before building?

3. Product Context

Our original idea was inspired by the concept of an AI bookkeeping assistant capable of converting invoices and receipts into organized financial records.

However, after conducting customer discovery, we realized that full bookkeeping is too broad for an MVP and does not represent the highest-value pain point for our target users.

Research consistently showed that distributors primarily struggle with receivables management rather than accounting itself.

As a result, we narrowed our product scope.

Current Product Statement:

A bilingual mobile receivables assistant for Pakistani FMCG micro-distributors that converts invoice photos and WhatsApp screenshots into reviewed receivable records, tracks outstanding customer balances, assists with payment follow-ups, and records payments through a simple mobile workflow.

4. Target Users

Primary Target User

Pakistani Small FMCG Micro-Distributors

Typical characteristics:

- Sell products on credit
- Supply retailers or local shops
- Process invoices daily
- Maintain customer balances
- Perform regular payment collection
- Operate with small teams
- Use paper documents, WhatsApp, Excel, or basic accounting software

Out of Scope

The following users are not our initial target market:

- Large enterprises using mature ERP systems

- Corporate finance departments
 - Tax consultants
 - Inventory-heavy ERP users
 - General bookkeeping businesses
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5. Research Methodology

Customer discovery was conducted using multiple channels.

Direct Customer Conversations

Business owners and distributors were interviewed to understand their current receivables workflow.

Online Community Discussions

Questions were posted in Pakistani business communities on Facebook and LinkedIn to gather qualitative insights from distributors, wholesalers, manufacturers, and accountants.

Expert Validation

Additional conversations were conducted with:

- ERP developers
- ERP client managers
- Accounting professionals

These interviews were used to understand existing software capabilities and validate technical assumptions rather than identify customer problems.

6. Current Customer Workflow

The following workflow was repeatedly observed during customer research.

Credit Sale

↓

Invoice Created

↓

Paper / WhatsApp / Screenshot



Manual Record Keeping



Customer Ledger



Outstanding Tracking



Phone Call / WhatsApp Follow-up



Payment Received



Manual Balance Update

This workflow highlights several manual steps where information must be repeatedly entered, verified, or searched.

7. Key Customer Findings

Finding 1 – Outstanding receivables are difficult to track

The most significant challenge identified during research was maintaining visibility into outstanding customer balances.

Business owners frequently need to know:

- Which customer owes money?
- How much is pending?
- Which invoices are overdue?

This information is often not immediately available.

Product Impact: The MVP should provide a customer-wise receivables dashboard.

Finding 2 – Information is scattered

Invoices and payment information are commonly spread across multiple sources:

- Paper invoices
- WhatsApp screenshots
- Bill books

- Excel sheets
- Basic accounting software

Searching these sources wastes time and increases the likelihood of missing information.

Product Impact: Support invoice uploads from camera, gallery, PDFs, and WhatsApp screenshots.

Finding 3 – Duplicate manual work exists

Several participants described entering the same information into multiple places.

Examples included:

- Paper register
- Accounting software
- Company portal
- Reports

Product Impact: Extract invoice information once and reuse it throughout the workflow.

Finding 4 – Payment follow-up is manual

Business owners regularly call customers or send WhatsApp messages to recover outstanding payments.

There is little prioritization of which customer should be contacted first.

Product Impact: Build a "Collections Today" screen with editable WhatsApp reminders.

Finding 5 – Trust is essential

Accounting professionals consistently stated that financial entries should never be posted automatically.

Users expect to review AI-generated information before it affects financial records.

Representative customer quote:

"Being an accountant I will prefer to recheck it before posting even if it is 100% okay."

Product Impact: AI prepares drafts; users approve before posting.

Finding 6 – OCR introduces technical risk

Businesses use invoices with varying layouts.

Some invoices are printed while others contain handwritten information.

OCR accuracy may therefore vary considerably.

Product Impact: The MVP includes a mandatory review screen and focuses first on the minimum required fields (customer, date, amount, due date/credit days).

8. Validation of MVP Assumptions

Assumption	Status	Evidence
Distributors sell on credit	✓ Validated	Customer interviews
Tracking receivables is difficult	✓ Validated	Multiple discussions
Invoice information exists in different formats	✓ Validated	Customer feedback
Businesses manually follow up on payments	✓ Validated	Customer interviews
Users want AI assistance	✓ Validated	Community discussions
Users do not trust automatic posting	✓ Validated	Accountant interviews
OCR may struggle with inconsistent invoices	⚠ Needs further testing	ERP experts

9. Expert Validation

ERP Developer

Key observations:

- Mature ERP systems already automate accounting workflows.
- Invoice layouts differ significantly across businesses.

- OCR should not rely on fixed templates.

Product Decision: Focus on businesses with partially manual workflows rather than replacing ERP systems.

Accounting Professional

Key observations:

- Every accounting entry should be reviewed before posting.
- AI-generated drafts are acceptable if users retain control.

Product Decision: Introduce a mandatory review-and-approve workflow.

10. Product Decisions Influenced by Research

Customer Insight	Product Decision
Receivable tracking is the biggest pain	Focus MVP on receivables management
Information is fragmented	Accept images, PDFs, and screenshots
Duplicate data entry exists	Extract once and reuse
Payment follow-up is manual	Add WhatsApp reminder workflow
Users verify financial entries	Human approval before posting
OCR accuracy varies	Review extracted fields before confirmation
ERP already automates accounting	Do not compete with ERP

Research Traceability Matrix

Research Finding	Evidence Source	Product Decision
Distributors struggle to track outstanding payments	Facebook discussions, business owner interviews	Focus MVP on receivables dashboard
Information is scattered across paper and WhatsApp	Multiple customer conversations	Support image, PDF, and WhatsApp uploads
Users verify accounting entries	Accountant interview	Add review & approval before posting
Invoice formats vary	ERP developer	Narrow OCR scope for MVP
Manual payment follow-ups consume time	Business owners	Build WhatsApp reminder workflow

11. Risks & Open Questions

Key Risks

- OCR accuracy on handwritten and mixed Urdu/English invoices.
- Different invoice layouts across suppliers.
- User adoption if the workflow changes significantly.
- Building beyond the defined MVP scope.

Open Questions

- What percentage of invoices are handwritten?
 - How many unique invoice formats does a typical distributor receive?
 - What OCR accuracy is acceptable to users?
 - What is the average number of invoices processed per day?
 - Do users prefer mobile-only or mobile + web?
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12. Next Research Steps

1. Interview 10–15 additional FMCG distributors.
 2. Collect 20–30 real invoice samples.
 3. Test OCR providers using real documents.
 4. Observe one distributor's receivables workflow end to end.
 5. Validate the payment reminder experience with pilot users.
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13. Appendix

Representative Customer Quotes

"Being an accountant I will prefer to recheck it before posting even if it is 100% okay."

"Invoice formats change from client to client."

"We still use manual records before entering data into software."

"Tracking outstanding payments and following up with customers takes significant time."